

Origin essentialism

PHIL UA-78 Metaphysics

Prof. Cian Dorr

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De re modal claims

A distinction

De re modal claims are those which, intuitively speaking, concern the properties it is necessary or possible for *particular objects* to have.

‘Benjamin Franklin could have been seven feet tall’ is a *de re* modal claim about Franklin. ‘Bifocals could have been invented by someone seven feet tall’ isn’t.

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Formally, we can say that a modal sentence is *de re* on a certain reading if that reading is logically equivalent to a sentence where an individual *variable* or *pronoun* occurs nonredundantly within the scope of a modal operator like 'possible' or 'necessary'.

- ▶ So, 'The inventor of bifocals could have been seven feet tall' is *de re* on the *the* > *could* reading, which is equivalent to 'For some object x , x is the inventor of bifocals and x could have been seven feet tall', but not on the *could* > *the* reading.
- ▶ Given Kripke's view of names, 'Franklin could have been 7 feet tall' is unambiguously equivalent to 'Franklin is an object x such that x could have been 7 feet tall', and thus unambiguously *de re*.

Some Kripkean questions about *de re* modality

- ▶ Could Queen Elizabeth II have originated from a different sperm and egg?
- ▶ Could Richard Nixon have been an inanimate object?
- ▶ Was the wooden lectern at which Kripke delivered *N&N* such that it could have been made of ice from the River Thames?
- ▶ Could any wooden table that was originally formed from a certain hunk of wood have, instead, been originally formed from a completely non-overlapping hunk of wood?

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Kripke suggests, cautiously, that the right answer to all of these questions is *no*. But it's much more important to him that they are *legitimate questions*—appropriate topics for philosophical debate.

Is there a special problem about de re modal claims?

Before Kripke, many philosophers (most famously, W. v. O. Quine) thought that there was something *wrong* with de re modal sentences. Maybe they are *meaningless*. Or maybe—more plausibly!—they are *ambiguous* in some distinctive way that other modal sentences are not.

- ▶ ‘Whether a *particular* necessarily or contingently has a property depends on the way it’s described’ (N&N, p. 40)

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- ▶ ‘Whether a *particular* necessarily or contingently has a property depends on the way it’s described’ (N&N, p. 40)

Kripke rejects this. Once we stipulate that ‘could’ means *metaphysical* possibility, there is no ambiguity in ‘*a* could be *F*’ (beyond whatever ambiguity there may be in ‘*a*’ and ‘*F*’).

De re attitude reports contrasted with de re modal sentences

The “special ambiguity” view has something to be said for it when it comes to *propositional attitude* operators.

‘For some person x who works for the *Daily Planet*, Lois believes that x can fly’ *does*, arguably, have both true and false readings, which it’s natural to disambiguate by talking about ‘the way it’s described’.

- *Maybe* this is just a matter of the verb ‘believe’ having multiple interpretations: but whatever the dimension of variability is, it is hard to detect any corresponding variability in sentences like ‘Lois believes that there are people who can fly’.

Kripke’s rejection of the “special ambiguity” view for metaphysical modality goes hand in hand with his rejection of the idea that modals (interpreted non-epistemically) are sensitive to the differences between different ways of referring to the same object/property/state of affairs in the way attitude reports seem to be.

Is the truth about de re modality *boring*?

A very different reason for not wanting to engage with Kripke's questions would be some radical view that spits out answers to all of them in one fell swoop, obviating further debate. These come in two opposite sorts:

Hyper-Essentialism If object x has property F , then it is metaphysically necessary that if x exists, x has F .

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- The latter view is so extreme that it's inconsistent: it's possible (since actually true) that there is something that is not identical to NYU, but by NI, the property of not being identical to NYU is not one that NYU could have. Next class we will discuss a somewhat less extreme view that avoids this problem but still has lots of radical consequences (e.g., that Saul Kripke could have been a poached egg).

Is the truth about de re modality *boring*?

Hyper-Essentialism is so radical that it's hard to know what to make of it: it *pervasively rejects beliefs that we all take for granted in everyday life*.

- ▶ When we say 'I could have missed the bus this morning', we are not talking about metaphysical modality: but since metaphysical modality is supposed to be *broader than* these everyday interpretations of 'could', the truth of such remarks *implies* the truth of the corresponding ascriptions of metaphysical possibility.

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By contrast, since it's unclear how often the topic of metaphysical possibility comes up in everyday life, the radical claims characteristic of Extreme Anti-Essentialism (e.g. that Kripke could have been a poached egg) are not in clear conflict with our 'everyday' beliefs. It's more of a theoretical question.

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The general challenge

Here's Kripke explaining why he thinks Elizabeth couldn't have been the biological child of the Trumans:

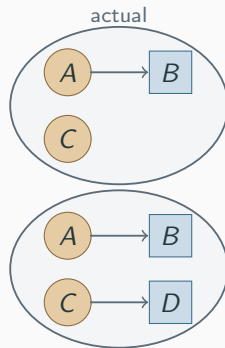
- » They might have had a child resembling her in many properties. Perhaps in some possible world Mr. and Mrs. Truman even had a child who actually became the Queen of England and was even passed off as the child of other parents. This still would not be a situation in which this very woman whom we call 'Elizabeth II' was the child of Mr. and Mrs. Truman, or so it seems to me.

Kripke here seems to be raising a challenge for those who think that Elizabeth could have been a biological child of Mr and Mrs Truman. Given that it's not *sufficient* for this to happen that Mr and Mrs Truman have a child that is named 'Elizabeth', becomes Queen, etc., what further details could we add to the possible situation that would *explain*, why, in this situation, it is Elizabeth herself who is the child of Mr and Mrs Truman?

The argument in footnote 56

Here's the closest Kripke gets to an honest-to-goodness *argument* for any essentialist claim:

- » Let '*B*' be a name (rigid designator) of a table, let '*A*' name the piece of wood from which it actually came. Let '*C*' name another piece of wood. Then suppose *B* were made from *A*, as in the actual world, but also another table *D* were simultaneously made from *C*. (We assume that there is no relation between *A* and *C* which makes the possibility of making a table from one dependent on the possibility of making a table from the other.) Now in this situation $B \neq D$; hence, even if *D* were made by itself, and no table were made from *A*, *D* would not be *B*. (N&N p. 114)



The argument in footnote 56

How does Kripke argue against the following position:
One thing that could have happened is that *B* was made of *A* while a different table was made out of *C*. But *another* thing that could have happened is that *B* was made of *C* while a different table was made out of *A*?

